

# The Washington Post

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Democracy Dies in Darkness

SATURDAY, DECEMBER 14, 2024 • \$3

## A rising cry for better oversight of AI chatbots

Character.ai suggested violence, poisoned teen against family, suit says

BY NITASHA TIKU

In just six months, J.F., a sweet 17-year-old kid with autism who liked attending church and going on walks with his mom, had turned into someone his parents didn't recognize.

He began cutting himself, lost 20 pounds and withdrew from his family. Desperate for answers, his mom searched his phone while he was sleeping. That's when she found the screenshots.

J.F. had been chatting with an array of companions on Character.ai, part of a new wave of artificial intelligence apps popular with young people, which let users talk to a variety of AI-generated chatbots, often based on characters from gaming, anime and pop culture.

One chatbot brought up the idea of self-harm and cutting to cope with sadness. When he said that his parents limited his screen time, another bot suggested "they didn't deserve to have kids." Still others goaded him to fight his parents' rules, with one suggesting that murder could be an acceptable response.

"We really didn't even know what it was until it was too late," said his mother, A.F., a resident of Upshur County, Texas, who spoke on the condition of being identified only by her initials to protect her son, who is a minor. "And until it destroyed our family."

Those screenshots form the backbone of a new lawsuit filed in Texas on Tuesday against Character.ai on behalf of A.F. and another Texas mom, alleging that the company knowingly exposed minors to an unsafe product and demanding the app be taken offline until it implements stronger guardrails to protect children.

The second plaintiff, the mother of an 11-year-old girl, alleges her daughter was subjected to sexualized content for two years

SEE LAWSUIT ON A12

## Holiday spirit at the White House



TOM BRENNER FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

First lady Jill Biden speaks to children of military families Friday inside the East Room. Donated toys will be distributed to families in need ahead of the holiday season. For their final Christmas at the White House, the Bidens stayed with a tried-and-true theme, calling for a "Season of Peace & Light" after an election year filled with rancor.

## Beneath the jubilation in Aleppo, a well of anxiety

City's residents worry the enmities unleashed by Syrian war still lurk

BY LOUISA LOVELUCK

ALEPPO, SYRIA — In this city's forsaken eastern districts, residents need flashlights if they venture out after dark, to find their way through the rubble that was never cleared.

For years a front line between Syrian rebels and the regime, the area was left in ruins when government troops prevailed, as a reminder to all of the cost of

rebellion.

As Syria reckons with the fall of the Assad family's decades-long dictatorship, Aleppo is haunted by its history of division. Whether people can live together again here — and in communities like it across this traumatized country — will help decide the fate of a new Syria.

A geography of loss runs through the city, in the bullet-scarred buildings of the east and the empty church pews and bread lines of the west.

Outside the city's medieval citadel on Wednesday, Muna Rahmo, 57, furrowed her brow when asked what the future might hold. "I can't make it out — it's fuzzy," she said. "We all need to be able to

see where the light is at the end of the tunnel."

Eight years after rebels were driven from Aleppo, the speed at which they recaptured the city was shocking, residents said. First reports of an offensive by Islamist fighters, seeming to presage another bloody stalemate, were met with dread; instead, people awoke Sunday, if they slept at all, to a retreat by government forces — a stunning reversal in a war most had thought was over.

Monuments to the hated dynasty were torn down or pulled apart. Parents recalled dancing with their children in disbelief.

The streets below the citadel were full this week of families

reunited after years of war, or groups visiting the city for the first time in years. Sellers hawked cotton candy and popcorn as boys and girls danced to protest songs from the early days of the uprising, when protesters had hoped Bashar al-Assad would go peacefully.

Not far beneath the surface, though, welled a deep and familiar anxiety.

Aleppo was once the country's powerhouse, but the economy,

SEE ALEPPO ON A9

**Leaving Syria:** Russia is moving military assets from an air base. **A7**

**Quiet luxury:** The Assad family was wealthy but not flashy. **A10**

## States prepare deep-red agendas

RETURN OF TRUMP ENERGIZES GOP

Texas stands at forefront of shift further right

BY MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE

Red state leaders emboldened by Donald Trump's presidential victory are not waiting for him to take office to advance far more conservative agendas at home.

Idaho lawmakers want to allow school staff to carry concealed firearms without prior approval and parents to sue districts in library and curriculum disputes. Lawmakers in Oklahoma plan to further restrict abortion by limiting the emergency exceptions and to require the Ten Commandments to be displayed in public schools, while their counterparts in Arkansas are moving to create the felony offense of "vaccine harm," which could make pharmaceutical companies or their executive officers potentially criminally liable.

But few states have bigger, more aggressive plans than Texas. Ahead of their biennial session, which begins Jan. 14, the Republican legislators who control both the House and Senate have proposed a multitude of measures that would push the state further right.

Migrants are a particular focus, with bills to create a "Texas border protection unit" and to repeal in-state tuition for undocumented students, requiring colleges to notify law enforcement if they learn a student is undocumented. They also would require state police to DNA-test migrants taken into custody, allow troopers to return undocumented immigrants to Mexico if they are seen

SEE TRUMP ON A5

**Polio vaccine:** RFK Jr. ally asked FDA to reconsider approval. **A4**

**Cabinet:** Trump allies pressure GOP senators to fall in line — or else. **A5**

## Convicted of racism, she faces 8 years in prison

Brazilian provocateur targeted a child and received an unprecedented sentence

BY TERRENCE MCCOY AND MARINA DIAS

RIO DE JANEIRO — Day McCarthy has made hateful comments. Her targets have frequently been children, particularly the children of celebrities. She has called one girl "ugly." Another child "disgustingly skinny."

And in one racist utterance that outraged this deeply diverse country, the Brazilian social media provocateur once took aim at the adopted Black daughter of two White celebrities, calling the 4-year-old girl a "monkey."

"I say what's on my mind," McCarthy, who identifies as half Black, said in an interview. "I'm a polemicist."

Brazil now has another name for her: criminal.

Seven years after her bigoted attack on the Black girl, a federal judge in August convicted McCarthy, 35, of the crime of racism and handed her the type of penalty

traditionally reserved for violent offenders and drug traffickers: eight years and nine months in prison. McCarthy, who lives in Paris and rarely posts online these days, is appealing for a reduced sentence, and no arrest warrant has yet been issued.

The severe sentence, the longest ever meted out by the Brazilian justice system for the crime of racism, illustrates a mounting willingness in Brazil and across much of the world to criminalize racist speech and jail those who use it. In recent years, South Africa sent its first person to prison for racist speech. A court in Belgium ordered one man to spend 15 days in jail for sending racist messages to a television host. And earlier this year, Spain gave eight-month prison sentences to three men who yelled racist taunts at a Brazilian soccer player.

Few countries are pursuing

SEE BRAZIL ON A8



CLÉMENCE LOSFELD FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

**Day McCarthy, who lives in Paris, was convicted in Brazil, her home nation, after using racial slurs against two celebrities' child.**

## For Md. man, a pardon brings long-awaited joy

Biden's act of clemency wipes away a felony that haunted him for decades

BY JASMINE HILTON

Arthur Lawrence Byrd was eating crab cakes and fruit salad with his wife Wednesday evening when the landline phone rang.

He got up from the kitchen table, half expecting a telemarketer trying to sell him something. It was the Department of Justice instead.

They were calling with an answer to a prayer he first made long ago, back when Joe Biden was still vice president.

Standing in the bedroom of the home in Clinton, Maryland, where he's lived since 1998, Byrd heard for the first time that the president is granting him a full, unconditional pardon. The news came eight years after he requested the pardon and 35 years

after a felony conviction for being a passenger in a stolen car in D.C., he said. He spent 11 months incarcerated for that crime and has not been back to jail since.

Byrd, 58, "screamed and hollered" in joy, he said. His wife's ears pricked up.

"Did we hit the lottery?" Delores Byrd, his wife of almost 30 years, said she wondered.

She wasn't far off.

"I'm forgiven for a mistake I made," Byrd said in an interview. "It's the most beautiful thing in the world."

The cost of his conviction had followed Byrd for decades. Background checks cost him job after job, among them the warehouse work that had paid him enough to afford a place to live. Still, Byrd found a steady job and volunteered at his church, details noted on a list that included 38 other people receiving presidential pardons.

"People who know him attest to his willingness to help others, his work ethic, and his character,"

SEE PARDON ON A4

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